

Should've, Would've, Would Still

When I worked at WNGM, an adorable television station in Athens, GA, I worked for the sales and production teams. That was odd. No one had done that before, and I imagine it was because they were quite different sets of characters. The production team was pretty obviously the AV club kids team that I had known from high school. Then I got. The sales team was a mystery of rivalry and strange competitive behavior.

I worked for Tammy. She was the sales manager. She was clearly the top sales person promoted to management of which she was unusually competent at. I say unusually because of the Peter principle. Later in life I would realize she was the proof that the rule was correct. I liked working for Tammy; she made sense.

The rest of the sales team... first, there was Larry. Never in your life have you met a man with a southern accent in a cheap suit and cheap haircut that you wouldn't call a country bumpkin. I did. But doing that made me dead wrong. Larry was by far the best salesman on the team; regularly doubling the second sales team member's numbers. I would bet that station owner wanted to promote Larry and Larry wouldn't do it for the *genuine* reason that Larry wouldn't be able to talk to his people anymore. Larry knew he had clients, but Larry also trusted he had friends.

Someone who brought \$100,000 in advertising was no different to Larry than someone who bought \$5,000. Larry *knew* their name, the name of their spouse, the names of their children. If he heard some state news that affected a segment of industry, he'd show up at your door and it wasn't because he wanted to tell you to buy advertising on WNGM to support your

business. No, he was there to help. If advertising could help, so be it, but also maybe he could help you get ahold of somebody that could help because Larry knew *everybody* and *everybody* like Larry. I came to admire Larry. He saw the big picture in a way that not even the station manager or owner saw. Larry just *got* the whole fucking broadcast area. The owners and broadcasters in their towers never deigned to set foot in the rural parts of their TV district. Larry did.

I don't know what happened to Larry, but if he didn't become a politician, the world lost a good one. I'm fairly certain he had no time for that bullshit. He had other wisdom to let me know that he was no hayseed. He told me once, "Russell, you know how you're at a fancy restaurant?" Me, being a poor college student said, "No."

"The waiters don't say anything."

"If you're at a *fancy* restaurant, the waiters walk up to the table, but they just check—they don't interrupt the conversation."

I'll be damned if that hasn't proven true for the rest of my life. Whatever I initially thought of Larry, I was wrong. His power of sales was disarming people by simply being genuine.

Let me dispense with the rest of the sales team. There was Aaron, barely older than me, out of college, no idea what he was doing. Good guy though. There was Cassandra and you know how some people just leave no impression at all somehow? There was Lan's (TV Station Manager DUDE) WIFE—Rachel.

Rachel. If I were in your position and only there because my asshole of a husband either made me work in the sales department to prove something *or* because I was so incompetent I couldn't get a job doing something else, well, I'd be dour, too. I mean, there's nepotism and that's the only possible reason that Lan was in charge of that place—his father owned it. What a bozo, Lan. What a talk without a walk. What a suit

wearing the opposite of actually giving a shit like Larry did. If there were any justice in this world, Lan would be working his ass off for Larry. Only there can never be justice in the world because Larry would never have it that way. But, putting your own wife in the sales team pool of your own business and making her compete? There's a sickness in the head there.

And then, the point of this whole diatribe is the beautiful blonde whose name I swear I cannot remember. Let's call her Paysley—typical southern blonde moniker. She understood sex and how men sexually objectified her and I've no idea if it was conscious or not, but she. Got. It. Her account holders just wanted her to come around again to run up against their cheap slacks in her super short skirts. (Check out the song "Short Skirt, Long Jacket" by Cake and you'll understand a bit more.) Paysley "confided" to me—she wanted me to know—it took her at least *two hours* to get ready in the morning. I failed to understand why that was bragging or efficient. So much makeup was on her face it just looked toxic to me. And yet, she was right behind Larry in sales numbers and super cool with that.

One day, Paysley shows up to the station with new boobs. It is *obvious*. She makes it so. She is happy to be showing them off after missing from the office for something like two weeks. (Wonder what the conversation between her and Lan was like?)

I got to walk into the "director's room"—the AV Kids' lab—because I had demonstrated to the director that not only could I make cool sales brochures and folders but I could take a 2d logo and turn it into a 3D computer animation! That was a gold mine for local television in 1995! So, the director and the "cinematographer" liked to have me around after I demonstrated this CGI skill as well as my other exquisite geek knowledge of shit like old Doctor Who. I genuinely don't know what to call the "cinematographer"—he was more than just a cameraman—but the *key*

point is that both of the production guys had the same name: Rich. Or maybe Gary. Or... it really doesn't matter. They had the same name.

We're sitting amongst the suite of television screens playing old reruns of WKRP tapes that Lan, in his genius, bought from syndication conferences in Las Vegas. (Another excuse for him to travel to Las Vegas.) Rich or Gary says to Rich or Gary, "So, yeah, she just asked me to squeeze her knockers."

The other Rich or Gary says, "Me too! What'd you do man?"

"I didn't know what to do. Was it a honka-honka situation?" And he pantomimed squeezing ripe fruit with both hands, which caused me to laugh so hard I doubled over. But, it's not what you think. It's not because of boob-squeezing like fruit. It killed me because there was no horn-honking involved.

I can not, in this short amount of time, explain my brain. I cared less about *that* he squeezed her boobs or that he would do it in the way my naive imagination imagined it. In my fantasia, he pressed her new bonbons like he would a car horn. Palm on and flat against her rib cage. The thought of that, of just pressing on a woman's breasts—it just doubled me over.

Rich or Gary looked at me in confusion, but also happy because he *was* making a joke—just not the one I had got.

Boobs were discussed in the production room. Later in the day, Paysley found me and cornered me and wanted to show me her new breasts. She had a very sweet and entirely fake Southern accent. I mean, not fake, she played it up. I had gone to theater school; I knew when I was being had by pretend. But I'm also dumb in this way. Here is a very attractive woman asking twenty-year-old me to feel her up. She literally said, "What do think of these? You wanna touch 'em?"

I responded, "How?"

Whatever charge in the air there might have been just stopped. But I continued, "I mean, would you like me to test their tensile strength? What quality are you looking for? They look like breasts. Is the weight important to you?"

Whatever situation she had pinned me in, she tossed me back into the lake out of either pity or confusion. I'm not sure which.